BOOKS

A Life in Diplomacy

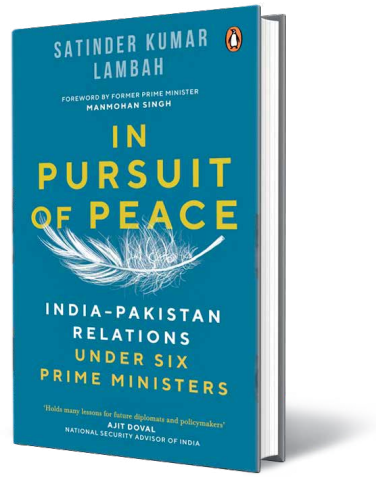
By T.C.A Raghavan

Much of the late S.K. Lambah's half-century-long sojourn in diplomacy had to do with Pakistan. Even without the Pakistan interface, his would have been a most distinguished career, serving as he did as ambassador to Germany and Russia. Yet, it was diplomacy with Pakistan that will constitute his legacy.

In this book, Lambah provides in part a historical recap of Pakistan's evolution, an anecdotal journey of his own engagement with it, and finally a reflection on the value of diplomacy as an instrument in dealing with our most recalcitrant of neighbours. There is, in addition, a valuable chapter on post-9/11 Afghanistan, where Lambah played a major role both in ensuring that the Indian voice was heard and in bringing about a settlement on which the new architecture of governance was constructed by the US.

Lambah's interface with Pakistan began with its dissolution in 1971; he was in Dacca in January 1972 as part of the small diplomatic mission established in the immediate aftermath of the emergence of Bangladesh. A few years later, he was in Islamabad for a long stint as India's deputy high commissioner. In the 1980s, he headed the Pakistan-Afghanistan-Iran desk in the ministry of external affairs and then, in the 1990s, he was back in Islamabad as High Commissioner.

Yet, this long exposure had a prehistory. This was a familial background in pre-1947 Peshawar and Lahore: both he and his wife came from prominent families of these cities. This gave him an access that deepened his insights, including into the mindset of his interlocutors and of Pakistan's ruling elite. Through this prism, these memoirs take us through half a century of the



IN PURSUIT OF PEACE
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India-Pakistan roller-coaster of terrorist attacks, hijackings, near-conflict situations and crisis management, but also attempts at constructive diplomacy. This is a journey through military dictators, generals and politicians and through the tenures of Indian prime ministers from Indira Gandhi onwards. Lambah argues that the Prime Minister of India has the strongest impact in determining the mould of this fraught relationship, because it's "difficult to identify and justify a particular course of action from a mere examination of the material at hand"; and "bureaucratic and political processes tend to favour safe options and status quo". It's the top-down decision that makes a difference as "the wheels are set in motion and the choreography works itself out".

S.K. Lambah's reflections on the challenges in India-Pakistan diplomacy remain clear-sighted

After his retirement as Indian ambassador in Moscow in 2001, Lambah was appointed as Special Envoy for Afghanistan by Prime Minister A.B. Vajpayee. With the change in government in 2004, PM Manmohan Singh made him the Special Envoy for Pakistan. For over a decade, he was the "back channel"—negotiating with Pakistani counterparts the contours of a non-territorial 'solution' to Jammu and Kashmir that would enable both parties to claim that an honourable settlement had been reached. The book provides a great deal of granular and substantial detail of that process and for that alone would be a valuable addition to the existing literature on Indian diplomacy during that time. Though it failed because the dynamics of India-Pakistan relations changed, the progress it made remains a template.

Lambah's reflections remain clear-sighted about the challenges: "a fundamental change in attitude towards bilateral issues is unlikely to occur in the near future, expectations have therefore to be pegged at a realistic level". An intimate knowledge of Pakistan permeates the book—"Like radicalised people elsewhere, Pakistanis tend to view differences through the prism of religious dogma." He is also perceptive about the role of external powers—"As major powers realised Pakistan's extreme predilections and weakness, unfortunately Kashmir came to be regarded as a sort of quarry with which Pakistan's behaviour, responses and actions could be altered." However, Lambah's approach throughout also saw the big picture and recognised that "memories should not become perpetual shackles on shaping our future" and that "no country's destiny is immune from its relationship with neighbours".

Such dilemmas constitute the core of diplomacy with Pakistan and make the book invaluable for South Asia experts and general readers alike. ■

T.C.A. Raghavan *is a former high commissioner to Pakistan*